SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

THE RESTORATION OF THE English monarchy under Charles II in 1660 did nothing to improve relations with the Dutch. A faction at the English court associated with Charles's brother James, Duke of York, was determined to challenge Dutch dominance of world trade. In 1664 the English attacked Dutch slave trading posts on the west coast of Africa, captured New Amsterdam in North America, which they renamed New York, and seized Dutch merchant ships. War was formally declared in March 1665. The Dutch were building a new navy with larger warships, although this was still incomplete. Hostilities opened with a stunning defeat for the Dutch at Lowestoft. Vigorous action by Dutch leader Johan de Witt and the return of Admiral Michiel de Ruyter from colonial duties then shifted the balance in favor of the Dutch. England was struck by the disasters of the Plague and the Fire of London, while royal finances collapsed. The bold Dutch raid on the Medway in 1667 was a final humiliation for England's rulers, who hastily signed a peace that left them no gains but the little-valued possession of New York.

SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

LOWESTOFT



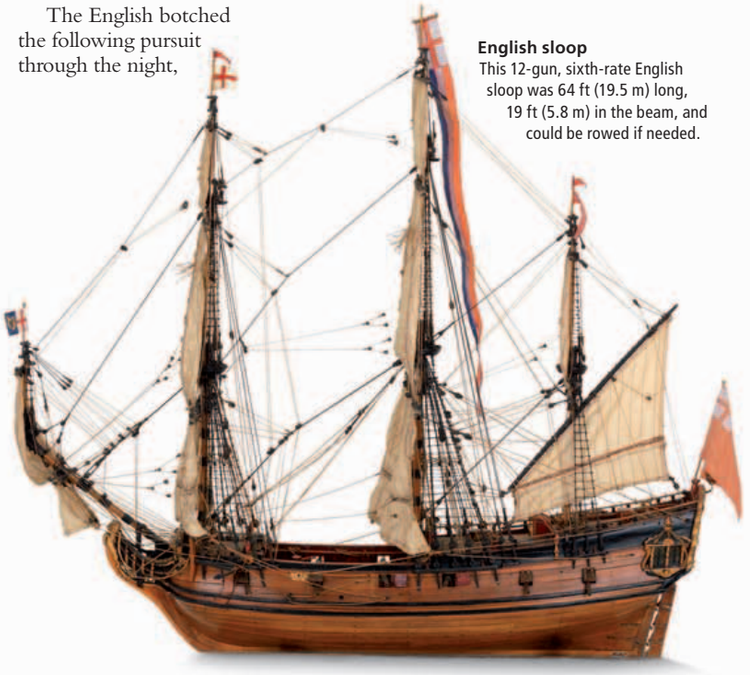
Date June 13, 1665
Forces English: 109 ships; Dutch: 103 ships
Losses English: 1 ship lost; Dutch: 17 ships lost

Location Off Suffolk, eastern England

When war broke out the Dutch government had great confidence in the strength of its new navy. Admiral Jacob van Wassenaer Obdam was sent to seek out the English fleet and give battle. Aware of Dutch intentions, the English were waiting for Obdam when he appeared off East Anglia.

There was little tactical coherence to a battle fought in shifting winds. The English commander James, Duke of York, struggled to maintain a formation but the Dutch engaged pell-mell. The combat grew in ferocity. James, on his flagship *Royal Charles*, narrowly escaped death when chain-shot decapitated several courtiers standing alongside him. Obdam was less fortunate. After a lengthy duel with *Royal Charles*, his flagship *Eendracht* exploded, killing Obdam and almost all those on board. After Obdam's death, the Dutch had no overall commander. Panicking Dutch captains began to flee back across the North Sea piecemeal. Several ships became entangled together in the confusion and were subsequently set ablaze by English fireships. Vice Admiral Cornelis Tromp distinguished himself by organizing a rearguard action to cover the withdrawal.

The English botched the following pursuit through the night, allowing most of the Dutch ships to regain the safety of the Texel shallows. Still, the Dutch had two ships sunk, six burned, and nine captured, plus some 6,000 men killed or taken prisoner. It was the heaviest Dutch defeat of the three Anglo-Dutch Wars.



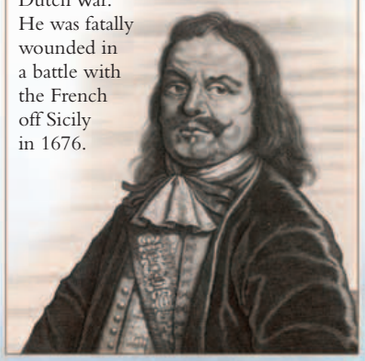
English sloop
This 12-gun, sixth-rate English sloop was 64 ft (19.5 m) long, 19 ft (5.8 m) in the beam, and could be rowed if needed.

1607–1676

MICHIEL DE RUYTER

DUTCH ADMIRAL

Spending more than six decades at sea and fighting in over 40 maritime battles, Michiel Adrianzoon de Ruyter was the greatest Dutch naval commander of the 17th century. Going to sea as a boy, he worked his way up to merchant captain before proving his worth as a naval commander in the First Anglo-Dutch War. He fought the English in West Africa and the Caribbean, and liberated some 2,500 Christian slaves from the Barbary pirates in the Mediterranean, before returning to take command of the Dutch navy in August 1665. He led his fleet to a hard-fought victory in the Four Days Battle, but only held nominal command in the raid of the Medway. His finest hour came fighting against the odds in the Third Anglo-Dutch War. He was fatally wounded in a battle with the French off Sicily in 1676.



SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

BERGEN



Date August 13, 1665
Forces English: 14 warships; Dutch: 60 merchant ships
Losses none

Location Bergen, Norway

After the English victory at Lowestoft, a Dutch merchant fleet took shelter at Bergen in Norway, then ruled by the king of Denmark. On attempting to capture the fleet, the English, commanded by Rear Admiral Thomas Teddiman, failed to win the Danes' cooperation and were battered by the guns of a fortress commanding the bay. The Dutch also kept up a brisk fire, forcing the English to withdraw.

SECOND ANGLO-DUTCH WAR

FOUR DAYS BATTLE



Date June 11–14, 1666
Forces English: 79 ships; Dutch: 84 ships
Losses English: 10 ships; Dutch: 4 ships

Location Between England and Flanders

By June 1666, France had gone to war with England and the Dutch had strengthened their navy with a substantial shipbuilding program. So when George Monck, Duke of Albemarle, came upon the Dutch fleet anchored off Dunkirk on June 11, he had only 56 ships to Michiel de Ruyter's 84. Monck nonetheless attacked, precipitating the bloodiest battle of the Anglo-Dutch Wars.

In the first day's fighting English Vice Admiral William Berkley was killed by a musket ball in the throat as he resisted the boarding of his ship, *Swiftsure*. Dutch Lieutenant Admiral Cornelis Evertsen was cut in half by a shot from Rear Admiral John Harman's flagship *Henry*, which had refused to strike despite being on fire and part of its crew jumping overboard in panic. By the end of the second day, with only 29 ships in fighting condition, Monck was desperately trying to disengage. Late on the third day Prince Rupert's ships tardily arrived to even the odds, but when Rupert's flagship *Royal James* was dismasted the following morning his squadron left Monck to face de Ruyter unaided. After further heavy losses (totalling 2,000 killed) the English disappeared into a fog bank and de Ruyter abandoned the pursuit.

